Decide What to Prepare for Mom Now and What Can Honestly Wait

Four prompts to sort the things worth doing while Mom is well from the decisions that aren't due, break the preparation into pieces others can take, and name the events that would wake the plan up.

Where you are

Mom is fine, and you'd like to keep it that way without a scramble later. Someone in the family wants to tour places now. Someone else doesn't want to talk about it at all. You want a plan that gets things ready without forcing anything.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say which preparation is worth doing this season, which decisions you're deliberately not making yet, which pieces you'll ask others to take, and what change would bring the family back to the plan.

A one-page plan with four headings: Worth Doing Now, Deliberately Waiting, Preparation to Share, and What Would Wake This Plan Up.

Before you start

- Everything anyone in the family has suggested doing, including the ideas you disagree with.
- What Mom herself has said she wants, if she's said it.
- A note about who tends to end up doing things. You don't need agreement from everyone to start.

PROMPT 1

Sort now from not yet

WHY THIS MATTERS

The relative who wants to tour places and the one who won't discuss it are both reacting to the same thing: no one has separated preparation from decisions. Gathering papers is preparation. Choosing a building is a decision, and it isn't due.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Every suggestion the family has made, including the ones you think are premature.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> My mother is well, and the family has started talking about getting ready. Here is everything anyone has suggested:
>
> [PASTE THE SUGGESTIONS]
>
> Sort them into three lists: USEFUL NOW, for preparation that helps no matter what happens; NOT YET, for decisions that would commit Mom to something; and NEEDS A CONVERSATION FIRST, for items the family or Mom hasn't talked through. For each NOT YET item, write one sentence on what would have to be true before it's worth deciding. Do not recommend a living arrangement or suggest that Mom should move.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A USEFUL NOW list that nobody in the family would object to.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the three lists to the family and ask only one question: did I put anything in the wrong list?

PROMPT 2

Break the preparation into pieces others can take

WHY THIS MATTERS

Preparation lands on one person because it looks like one big job. Broken into afternoons, most of it can be done by a sibling three states away.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The USEFUL NOW list.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the preparation worth doing now for my mother:
>
> [PASTE THE USEFUL NOW LIST]
>
> Break each item into pieces small enough to do in an afternoon. For each piece, give me: WHAT KIND OF EFFORT (a phone call, paperwork, a conversation, reading), ABOUT HOW LONG, and COULD SOMEONE OUT OF TOWN DO IT. Mark any piece that really can only be done by one particular person, and say why. Don't put names on anything. I want to see how much of this could be spread around before we talk about who takes what.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many pieces say yes to COULD SOMEONE OUT OF TOWN DO IT.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick one piece and ask the relative who's offered the least whether they'd take it.

PROMPT 3

Name the changes that would wake the plan up

WHY THIS MATTERS

A plan with no trigger is a plan nobody reopens. The triggers that work are things you'd notice anyway: a fall, a helper moving away, Mom saying she's lonely.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first two prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is my mother's plan so far, including the decisions we're deliberately not making yet:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 AND 2]
>
> List the changes we could actually notice that would mean one of the NOT YET items has become due. Include changes in Mom, changes in the people who help her, and changes in the household. For each one, name the NOT YET item it connects to and who the family would talk to first: Mom herself, her doctor, or a care consultant. Don't describe what any change would mean for her health or what care she'd then need.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Each NOT YET decision paired with at least one noticeable change.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask Mom which of these changes she'd want you to notice, and which she'd rather tell you about herself.

PROMPT 4

Put the plan on one page

WHY THIS MATTERS

One page the family has seen is worth more than a folder one person keeps. This is the page you'll open when a trigger happens, and the one you'll check against on the date you choose.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Everything from the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything we've worked out about getting ready for my mother's care:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Put it on one page with four headings: WORTH DOING NOW, DELIBERATELY WAITING, PREPARATION TO SHARE, and WHAT WOULD WAKE THIS PLAN UP. At the bottom, add a line that reads “Next time we look at this:” and leave the date blank for us to fill in. Don't add a timeline for a move, a recommended setting, or names next to tasks. Keep the NOT YET items worded as things we've chosen to wait on, not things we've ruled out.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page Mom could read without feeling that anything has been decided about her.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Write a date on the bottom line, share the page with the family, and start the next step below.

Give the plan a baseline

A plan you'll revisit later needs a clear picture of today to compare against. The care interview records Mom's situation area by area in a Family Care Profile. When one of your triggers happens, that profile is what shows you and a professional what has actually changed.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›